

AETHER FORGE: PROTOCOL ZERO

Game Design Document

1. CORE CONCEPT

Aether Forge: Protocol Zero is a seamless open-world action RPG that fuses the **stage-select progression and boss-weapon acquisition** of classic Mega Man with the **strategic depth of MOBAs**, the **persistent character growth of MMORPGs**, and the **mechanical granularity of D&D 5th Edition**—reimagined for real-time, roundless combat.

Set in the shattered megacity of **Nexus-7**, a world perpetually shrouded in anomalous fog that warps reality, players control **Runners**—cybernetically enhanced operatives who delve into procedurally corrupted sectors to extract Aether Cores, defeat Sector Lords, and uncover the truth behind the Fog.

“The Fog doesn’t hide monsters. It makes them. And sometimes... it makes you one too.”

2. WORLD SETTING: NEXUS-7

The Shattered Megacity

Once humanity’s greatest achievement—a continent-spanning arcology—Nexus-7 was fractured by the **Aether Collapse**, an event that unleashed raw magical energy into the city’s infrastructure. Now, the city exists as a patchwork of **Sectors**, each isolated by the **Veil Fog**, a sentient mist that obscures vision, corrupts technology, and spawns hostile entities.

The Fog of War (Literal & Mechanical)

- **Dynamic Visibility:** The Fog is not just visual—it actively consumes information. Minimap data decays. Enemy positions become uncertain. Even party member locations can drift on the HUD.
- **Fog Density Tiers:**
 - **Shroud:** Standard fog. Reduced visibility, hidden enemies until proximity.
 - **Mist:** Moderate corruption. Environmental hazards, distorted audio, false radar pings.
 - **Void:** Extreme zones. Complete sensory deprivation without specialized gear. High risk, high reward.
- **Fog Reactivity:** Player actions (combat, abilities, movement speed) can attract the Fog’s attention, spawning **Fog Tides**—waves of escalating enemies.

Factions & Lore

- **The Architects:** Pre-Collapse scientists seeking to restore Nexus-7. Masters of technology and order.
 - **The Hollowed:** Cultists who embrace the Fog. They wield corrupted magic and reshape flesh.
 - **The Fringers:** Scavengers and outcasts who thrive in the chaos. Opportunistic and resourceful.
 - **The Protocol:** Enigmatic AI constructs that maintain the city’s failing systems. Neutral arbiters with inscrutable motives.
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3. GAMEPLAY PILLARS

Pillar 1: Mega Man Progression — “Acquire, Adapt, Overcome”

- **Sector Lords:** Each major Sector is ruled by a powerful boss (the “Sector Lord”). Defeating them grants their **Signature Protocol**—a unique ability, weapon, or passive that can be equipped.
- **Protocol Fusion:** Acquired Protocols can be combined. Defeat the Pyro-Lord to get Flame Dash; defeat the Volt-Lord to get Thunder Strike; fuse them into **Plasma Surge**.
- **Weakness Chains:** Sector Lords have elemental/type weaknesses to other Lords’ Protocols, encouraging strategic progression order—just like Mega Man’s rock-paper-scissors boss design.

Pillar 2: MOBA Combat — “Skill Shots, Positioning, Cooldowns”

- **Ability-Based Combat:** No auto-attacks. Every action is an ability with a hitbox, cast time, and cooldown.
- **MOBA Controls:** WASD movement + mouse aim. Q/W/E/R for abilities, D/F for summoner spells (utility skills).
- **Resource Management:** Instead of MOBA mana, use **Aether Cells**—a regenerating resource with burst potential, similar to D&D’s spell slots but regenerating dynamically based on combat actions.
- **Crowd Control Hierarchy:** Stuns, roots, silences, knockbacks—all with diminishing returns and counter-play options (cleanses, tenacity stats).

Pillar 3: D&D 5e Depth — “Stats, Proficiency, Advantage”

- **The Six Attributes:** Strength, Dexterity, Constitution, Intelligence, Wisdom, Charisma directly govern ability scaling, hit chance, and resistance calculations.
- **Proficiency System:** Weapons, armor types, tool kits, and Protocol categories have proficiency ratings. Being proficient adds a scaling bonus (like D&D’s proficiency bonus) and unlocks advanced techniques.
- **Advantage/Disadvantage:** Roll two dice and take the higher/lower—implemented as a **critical range modifier** in real-time combat. Having Advantage means your critical hit threshold drops by 5% (e.g., 20 → 19-20).
- **Saving Throws:** Instead of flat resistances, abilities prompt Saving Throws (Dexterity save to dodge a fireball, Wisdom save to resist mind control). Player stats vs. enemy DC.
- **No Combat Rounds:** All D&D mechanics are translated into real-time. “Bonus Actions” become instant-cast off-global-cooldown abilities. “Reactions” become counter-abilities triggered by enemy actions.

Pillar 4: ARPG Loot & Buildcraft — “Numbers Go Up, Builds Go Deep”

- **Gear Tiers:** Common → Uncommon → Rare → Epic → Legendary → Mythic.
- **Affix System:** Items roll with random affixes (+% Fire Damage, +Dexterity, Chance to Cast on Hit). Legendaries have unique modifiers that enable build archetypes.
- **Runewords:** Socketed gear can be enhanced with Aether Runes, creating powerful synergistic effects.
- **Build Diversity:** A “Fighter” class can be a tanky frontliner (Str/Con), a crit-based assassin (Dex/Cha), or a spellblade (Int/Str) depending on gear and Protocol choices.

4. CHARACTER SYSTEM

Classes (Runners)

Each class has a **D&D-style progression table** (levels 1–20) with **Subclass choices at level 3** (like D&D archetypes).

1. Vanguard (Fighter Analog)

- **Role:** Tank / Bruiser
- **Key Stat:** Strength / Constitution
- **Core Mechanic: Aegis Points** — a secondary health pool that regenerates out of combat. Abilities consume Aegis for enhanced effects.
- **Subclasses:**
 - **Juggernaut:** Immovable tank. Taunts, damage reduction, crowd control immunity.
 - **Blademaster:** Mobile duelist. Parries, ripostes, critical strike chains.
 - **Warlord:** Party support. Banners that buff allies, command abilities.

2. Specter (Rogue Analog)

- **Role:** Assassin / Scout
- **Key Stat:** Dexterity / Charisma
- **Core Mechanic: Shadow Meter** — builds through stealth actions and successful crits. Spend Shadow for devastating finishers or emergency escapes.
- **Subclasses:**
 - **Phantom:** Stealth specialist. Invisibility, trap-setting, backstab multipliers.
 - **Duelist:** 1v1 master. Riposte mechanics, single-target lockdown.
 - **Saboteur:** Area denial. Mines, poison clouds, environmental manipulation.

3. Channeler (Wizard Analog)

- **Role:** Artillery Mage / Controller
- **Key Stat:** Intelligence / Wisdom
- **Core Mechanic: Aether Weave** — spellcasting that leaves persistent zones. Weaves can be detonated or combined for combo effects.
- **Subclasses:**
 - **Elementalist:** Raw damage. Fire, ice, lightning with status effects.
 - **Chronomancer:** Time magic. Slows, hastes, rewind mechanics.
 - **Voidcaller:** Dark magic. Life drain, summons, corruption stacking.

4. Mediator (Cleric/Bard Analog)

- **Role:** Support / Buffer / Healer
- **Key Stat:** Wisdom / Charisma
- **Core Mechanic: Harmony** — buffs and heals generate Harmony stacks. At max Harmony, unleash a powerful ultimate ability.
- **Subclasses:**
 - **Luminary:** Pure healer. Shields, regeneration, resurrection.
 - **Arbiter:** Buffer/debuffer. Damage amps, resistance shreds, crowd control.
 - **Inquisitor:** Battle support. Damage-to-healing conversion, smite abilities.

5. Machinist (Artificer Analog)

- **Role:** Pet Class / Turret / Utility
- **Key Stat:** Intelligence / Dexterity
- **Core Mechanic: Scrap Pool** — defeated enemies and destroyed objects drop Scrap. Spend Scrap to deploy turrets, drones, or modify gear mid-mission.
- **Subclasses:**
 - **Engineer:** Defensive structures. Turrets, barriers, healing stations.
 - **Mechromancer:** Combat pets. Drone swarms, mech suits, autonomous allies.
 - **Alchemist:** Consumables and grenades. Buff potions, debuff bombs, healing mist.

Progression Systems

- **Level Cap:** 20 (D&D tiered progression)
- **Ability Points:** Each level grants points to unlock/upgrade abilities in a MOBA-style skill tree.
- **Feat System:** At levels 4, 8, 12, 16, 19, choose a Feat (like D&D) that provides a major passive or active ability.
- **Renown:** Account-wide reputation with factions, unlocking vendors, cosmetics, and narrative content.
- **Leaderboards:** Separate rankings for each game mode, updated weekly.

5. COMBAT SYSTEM: “THE NEXUS ENGINE”

Real-Time D&D Translation

D&D Concept	Real-Time Implementation
Action	Primary abilities (Q/W/E) with cooldowns
Bonus Action	Instant abilities (mouse thumb buttons) that don’ t trigger global cooldown
Reaction	Counter-abilities triggered by enemy tells (parry, dodge roll, spell reflect)
Movement	WASD with stamina-based sprint/dodge. No grid. Freeform 360°
Attack Roll	Accuracy stat vs. Evasion stat + RNG roll. Determines hit/miss/crit
Saving Throw	Player stat vs. Ability DC. Prompted visually (“DEX SAVE!” indicator)
Initiative	Not used. Real-time priority based on ability cast times and positioning
Spell Slots	Aether Cells —regenerate in combat via dealing/taking damage

MOBA Mechanics in ARPG Context

- **Last Hitting:** Killing blows on enemies grant bonus Aether and experience.
- **Warding:** Deployable scanner beacons that pierce the Fog in an area. Essential for survival.
- **Objectives:** In session modes, capturing control points or destroying structures yields team-wide buffs.
- **Item Active Effects:** Legendary gear has active abilities (like MOBA item actives) bound to keys.

Environmental Combat

- **Verticality:** Grapple hooks, wall-running, double jumps. High ground grants Advantage on ranged attacks.
 - **Destructible Cover:** Cover blocks line of sight but can be destroyed.
 - **Fog Manipulation:** Use abilities to clear Fog temporarily, or weaponize it against enemies.
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6. GAME MODES

A. OPEN WORLD: THE FRINGE (MMORPG Hub)

- **Seamless Zone:** A persistent, open-world sector where players gather, trade, form parties, and undertake dynamic events.
- **Safe Zones:** Architect-controlled outposts with vendors, crafting stations, and social hubs.
- **Contested Zones:** PvP-enabled areas with rare resources. Faction warfare for control points.
- **World Events:** Scheduled massive battles against Fog Titans. Hundreds of players cooperating.
- **No Session Timer:** Play at your own pace. This is where persistent progression happens.

B. EXTRACTION INSTANCES (PvE & PvP)

Inspired by Escape from Tarkov / Hunt: Showdown

- **The Setup:** Enter a corrupted Sector with a small squad (1–3 players). The map is dense with Fog, elite enemies, and environmental hazards.
- **The Objective:** Locate and extract Aether Cores while surviving. Cores come in tiers (Common to Prime). Higher tiers = higher risk.
- **PvE Variant:** Purely against AI. Fog Tides escalate over time, forcing extraction.
- **PvP Variant:** Multiple squads enter simultaneously. Can choose to cooperate or hunt each other. Death means losing carried gear (hardcore risk/reward).
- **Session Length:** 20–40 minutes.
- **Leaderboard:** Ranked by extraction value, survival rate, and PvP efficiency.

C. PARTY DUNGEONS (PvE)

Classic MMORPG dungeon design with MOBA boss mechanics

- **Group Size:** 4 players (1 Tank, 1 Healer, 2 DPS — flexible but optimal).
- **Structure:** 3–4 mini-boss encounters leading to a Sector Lord.
- **Mechanics:** Bosses have MOBA-style ability kits with clear tells, phases, and enrage timers.
- **Difficulty Tiers:** Normal → Heroic → Mythic → Nightmare. Higher tiers add mechanics and affixes.
- **Loot:** Guaranteed drops from bosses, with weekly lockouts for highest-tier rewards.
- **Session Length:** 30–60 minutes.
- **Leaderboard:** Speedrun rankings and no-death challenge rankings.

D. SOLO CHALLENGES (PvE)

Mega Man-style stage select

- **The Gauntlet:** Individual Sector Lord stages designed for solo play.
- **Protocol Mastery:** Complete challenges using specific Protocols for bonus rewards.
- **Ironman Mode:** One life. No checkpoints. Ultimate test of skill.
- **Session Length:** 10–20 minutes.
- **Leaderboard:** Clear time rankings, score-based rankings (style points for combos and no-damage runs).

E. BATTLEGROUNDS (PvP)

MOBA-inspired competitive PvP

- **Team Size:** 5v5 or 10v10.
- **Map Design:** Symmetrical maps with lanes, jungle sectors, and central objectives.
- **Mode Variants:**
 - **Aether Clash:** Classic MOBA. Destroy the enemy Nexus structure. Minions spawn in lanes. Players level up during the match (session-based, not persistent).
 - **Domination:** Hold control points to drain enemy tickets.
 - **Annihilation:** Team deathmatch with respawn limits.
- **Character Rules:** Players enter with their persistent character but stats are **normalized** to a competitive baseline. Gear affixes are disabled; only Protocol choices and skill matter.
- **Session Length:** 15–30 minutes.
- **Leaderboard:** Elo-based ranked system with seasonal rewards.

F. SEASONAL EVENTS

- **The Fog Surge:** Monthly event where the Fog expands, introducing new Sectors, new Sector Lords, and limited-time Protocols.
- **Faction Wars:** Week-long PvP campaigns where factions compete for territory control.
- **The Protocol Trials:** Rotating daily/weekly challenge modes with unique modifiers (e.g., “All abilities cost double but deal triple damage”).

7. PROGRESSION & LEADERBOARDS

Multi-Layered Progression

1. **Character Level:** 1–20. Unlocks abilities, feats, and stat points.
2. **Gear Score:** Average power level of equipped items. Determines access to high-tier content.
3. **Protocol Collection:** Account-wide library of acquired Sector Lord abilities.
4. **Renown:** Faction reputation for narrative and economic benefits.
5. **Mastery:** Per-weapon, per-class, per-mode experience that unlocks cosmetic and minor stat bonuses.

Leaderboard Categories

Category	Metric	Reward
Extraction King	Total Aether value extracted	Unique extraction-themed cosmetics
Sector Lord Slayer	Fastest solo Sector Lord kills	Title + mount
Dungeon Speedster	Fastest party dungeon clears	Guild banner + aura
Battleground Champion	Highest PvP Elo	Seasonal armor skin
Ironman Survivor	Longest Ironman streak	Exclusive portrait frame
Fog Walker	Most Fog-explored distance	Cartography-themed gear

Seasons

- **3-Month Seasons:** Each season introduces a new Sector, new Sector Lord, new Protocols, and a balance patch.
- **Seasonal Characters:** Optional fresh-start servers where everyone begins at level 1 for a race to max level and leaderboards.
- **Battle Pass:** Free and premium tracks with cosmetics, currency, and convenience items (no pay-to-win).

8. ECONOMY & CRAFTING

Currency

- **Credits:** Standard currency from vendors and quests.
- **Aether Shards:** Premium currency from extractions and high-tier content. Used for crafting, trading, and cosmetics.
- **Scrap:** Crafting material from dismantling gear.

Crafting

- **Modification:** Reroll affixes on gear using Aether Shards.
- **Infusion:** Upgrade gear tier, increasing base stats.
- **Protocol Imprinting:** Extract a Protocol from a defeated boss and imprint it onto gear for passive bonuses.
- **Runecrafting:** Create and combine Aether Runes for socketed gear.

Player Trading

- **The Bazaar:** A player-driven auction house in the Fringe.
- **Direct Trading:** Secure trade windows with inspection.
- **No Bind-on-Pickup for Most Gear:** High-value extraction loot can be sold, creating a thriving player economy.

9. ART & AUDIO DIRECTION

Visual Style

- **Neo-Noir Cyberpunk:** High-contrast lighting with deep shadows. Neon accents against industrial grays.
- **Fog Rendering:** Volumetric fog that reacts to light sources and player movement. The Fog is a character, not just an effect.
- **Character Design:** Mega Man-inspired silhouettes with modular armor pieces. Each class has a distinct profile readable in silhouette.
- **UI Design:** Diegetic HUD elements—health bars projected from wrist devices, minimap as a holographic drone companion.

Audio Design

- **Dynamic Soundscape:** The Fog muffles distant sounds but amplifies close threats. Audio is a gameplay mechanic.
 - **Ability Audio:** Each Protocol has a distinct audio signature, allowing skilled players to identify enemy abilities by sound alone.
 - **Music:** Synthwave-industrial hybrid. Intensifies during combat and Fog Tides.
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10. TECHNICAL ARCHITECTURE

Networking

- **Hybrid Server Model:** Open world runs on dedicated shards (100+ players). Session modes use instanced dedicated servers.
- **Rollback Netcode:** Essential for MOBA-style precision combat. Client-side prediction with server reconciliation.
- **Fog Synchronization:** Server-authoritative vision system. Players only receive data about entities they can actually see.

Anti-Cheat

- **Server-Side Validation:** All hit detection, loot rolls, and progression are server-authoritative.
- **Fog as Anti-Cheat:** The Fog system naturally limits information available to clients, making wallhacks and maphacks inherently difficult.

Platforms

- **PC (Primary):** Mouse and keyboard optimized. Full mod support for UI.
 - **Consoles:** Controller support with radial menus for abilities.
 - **Cross-Play:** Enabled for PvE. PvP has optional input-based matchmaking.
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11. MONETIZATION

Ethical Free-to-Play

- **Free:** Full game access, all classes, all modes, all levels.

- **Cosmetic-Only Premium:** Skins, emotes, mount variants, weapon effects.
 - **Convenience (Non-P2W):** Stash tabs, character slots, XP boosters (only for alt characters, not mains).
 - **Battle Pass:** \$10 per season. Contains cosmetics, credits, and crafting materials.
 - **No Loot Boxes:** Direct purchase or earnable through gameplay.
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12. DEVELOPMENT ROADMAP

Phase 1: Foundation (Months 1–12)

- Core combat engine (Nexus Engine)
- 3 classes (Vanguard, Specter, Channeler)
- Open World Fringe (1 zone)
- Solo Challenges (5 Sector Lords)
- Party Dungeons (3 dungeons)

Phase 2: Expansion (Months 13–24)

- 2 additional classes (Mediator, Machinist)
- Extraction Instances (PvE + PvP)
- Battlegrounds (2 modes)
- Crafting and economy
- Season 1 launch

Phase 3: Evolution (Months 25+)

- Guild housing and warfare
 - Mount and vehicle systems
 - Raid content (8-player)
 - User-generated content tools
 - Console release
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13. UNIQUE SELLING POINTS

1. **The Only Mega Man + MOBA + D&D Hybrid:** No other game combines stage-select boss progression with MOBA combat depth and D&D mechanical richness.
 2. **Fog as Gameplay:** The Fog of War is not just visual—it's a systemic threat that shapes every decision.
 3. **Session-Based Persistence:** Play a quick 15-minute solo challenge or a 3-hour extraction run. Your progress matters in both.
 4. **True Build Freedom:** D&D's open-ended character creation meets ARPG's itemization. No two characters need play the same.
 5. **Risk/Reward Extraction:** The adrenaline of hardcore survival games without the punishing permanent loss.
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14. ELEVATOR PITCH

Aether Forge: Protocol Zero is what happens when Mega Man's boss-rush progression, League of Legends' skill-shot combat, Diablo's loot addiction, and D&D's character depth collide in a fog-choked cyberpunk apocalypse. Choose your Runner. Hunt the Sector Lords. Steal their power. Survive the Fog. Climb the leaderboards. Or be consumed.

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